



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with KO

Anonymous (KO)

8 February 2019 – by phone

Interviewed by Olivia Dee (OD)

Transcribed by Jack Crangle

KO was interviewed over the telephone meaning that the interview was a little more disjointed than most. OD and KO could not see the other's face, read body language or be sure when the other had finished speaking. KO explained what she has learned about her birth mother and the Good Shepherd mother and baby home in which her birth mother stayed before KO's birth. KO also related the details she has been able to unravel about the three separate birth certificates she possesses: one for Northern Ireland, one for the Republic of Ireland, and one for the USA. Prior to the interview, KO sent photographs of her birth certificates and passport to assist Olivia Dee in piecing together her complicated movements as a baby and the legal documents that were generated to register her on both sides of the border in Ireland. KO was adopted by a couple from the USA and taken to live there when she was fourteen months old. However, it is clear that the couple had an agreement in place to adopt her and take her to the USA even before KO's birth. Her birth mother had signed a consent form that indicated that adoption to the USA was the outcome of the process. KO has only been able to piece together fragments about her first year of life from the documents she has and from conversations with her adoptive parents' family members: her adoptive mother and father died when she was a teenager. There is still a great deal that is unknown about her movements as an infant and their legality. Very soon after her birth she was taken from Northern Ireland into the

Republic of Ireland. Initially she was taken to a baby home and then to the home of one of her adoptive mother's relatives. She remained there for over a year, during which time her adoptive parents made arrangements for her removal to the USA. KO is not motivated to trace her birth parents and is more concerned that any illegality or impropriety about her adoption is investigated by the authorities on both sides of the Irish border.

To preserve KO's anonymity and that of her family names, places and dates are redacted where necessary. This is indicated by **.

OD: Okay so, yep, I've just double-checked and we're recording. So, I've just been having a look through the documents that you sent me [information about her birth and adoption sent to OD by KO prior to the interview].

KO: Yes.

OD: They're really fascinating. I'm trying, I'm trying to sort of put them in, in a comprehensive order, and I was wondering where you got the majority of them from?

KO: Well, I had the birth certificate from, let's see, the one that had *name of birth mother* as my mother, from as far back as I could remember because my adopted mother kept it in my baby book.

OD: Right.

KO: But I didn't get all of those documents until, I think, about, it must've been about seven years ago now when an aunt of mine was going through some of my mother's things, and she found them and she sent all of the documents to me.

OD: Wow. So sorry, is that ... your birth mother had them?

KO: No, my adopted mother had them.

OD: Oh okay. Wow. So how, how did your, how did you, kind of, try and build the picture of your birth mother from these documents? Because they're quite ... you have access to some quite interesting things? So, things like, you know, the reference from your birth [sic: it was adoptive father] father's friend at the *work location redacted* and things like that.¹

KO: Yeah.

OD: So that was just in a collection at your, at your adopted mother's house?

KO: Yes.

OD: Wow, okay.

KO: It was in her papers. She died when I was a teenager, and my aunt lived across the street from her. So, I moved in with her while I finished high school.

OD: Right.

¹ This referred to a discussion had before the recording. The reference was a character reference written for KO's adoptive father as part of his application to adopt a child.

KO: And she took over a lot of furniture from my mother's house. I don't know when she found those documents, but she didn't send them to me until seven years ago.

OD: Okay, no problem. And had you already been looking for your, for your adopted, sorry...

KO: It wasn't an active thing, and what happened, essentially, was after, my father died when I was fourteen, and then my mother died when I was sixteen. So, when I moved in with my aunt, I remembered that I had that birth certificate from my baby book. So that's when I just sent a letter to the, was it, it was the orphanage or it was the convent? I can't remember which one it was.

OD: Okay.

KO: And they said that they no longer kept those records, and I just let that go. And then I tried a couple more times when I got to be around thirty. First of all because people ... that's when people started to ask about my medical history and, seriously, you know, before it was like: "Well, I'm adopted." And they would just say: "Oh okay".

OD: Yeah.

KO: But then it was like: "Well, you might want to find out, you know".

OD: Yeah, exactly.

KO: So that started to concern me just a little bit. And I thought, well, I'll try again and I'll see if anything comes of this, and it didn't. And then the second time was when another aunt said that she remembered something about it, the birth being registered in, you know ... I think I sent you the document, but I sent a letter to a registry office in a county in Northern Ireland that she [the aunt] had her mind fixed on this being. But it wasn't that.

OD: Right.

KO: You know, in fact I think it was *location redacted*. And then, you know, it turned out it [she was confused and this linked to] *Good Shepherd mother and baby home where KO's birth mother spent time*...

OD: Right so, so you have, because you've got documents [birth certificates] from County *in Northern Ireland*, where *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* was, but then you [have] also got them from *location in Republic of Ireland*.

KO: Yeah.

OD: Yeah, which I thought was very interesting, which seems that you were moved.

KO: Oh yeah.

OD: Yeah. So do you, do you have any more information about that, did any-, was anyone able to help you with that? Like, why you were moved?

KO: No, nobody really remembers the process of the adoption. They do remember that, you know, if they were there then they were there to help. So for example when [the] adoption took place, that is, when I was born, my aunt and uncle who lived in *US state* were in Ireland for a vacation.

OD: Right.

KO: And they said that they would drive up to Northern Ireland and take me back to my grandmother's house, which is what they did. But that was all they did. They didn't know anything about the paperwork or anything, so they couldn't tell me anything more about that.

OD: Right, wow. So how, how have you been throughout this process? Has it been quite a, well, I can imagine that trying to, kind of, piece this together has been incredibly difficult?

KO: You know, it was just, I was really astounded by the whole, the documents that seemed to suggest there was movement of me from, over, across borders, and that this was probably not a unique case.

OD: Right.

KO: That the convent and the orphanage were probably doing this with a lot of babies.

OD: Yeah.

KO: The other thing was that, now this was just a rumour, that the person who was in charge of, I think it was the convent because it was a Mother Superior,

was, during my childhood, calling my parents and extorting money from them to keep silent about my whereabouts. Again, this is just a rumour, I don't know if it actually happened because I was just a child. This is another thing that's sort of family lore. It's not something that, you know, they kept receipts for.

OD: Right.

KO: So, again, you know more, sort of, corruption that was going on. And I had these documents and they, they aren't consistent with the movement and the consent for adoption.

OD: Yeah.

KO: So that's why, you know, I wanted to make these, you know, public.

OD: Yeah, and I really understand that, and I can understand the frustration as well. I think what struck me was that you, like I said, you have that original birth certificate and then you have this second birth certificate. And that, to me, kind of was quite concerning, because it seemed to kind of erase what had happened before that initial birth certificate.

KO: Right, yeah.

OD: Yeah, so I was wondering, were you offered an explanation for why there was that second birth certificate by anyone?

KO: No, not by anyone.

OD: Okay, no problem. So, in terms of, sort of, tracking, tracking family members down, have you been, have you had any success at all?

KO: I haven't really tried.

OD: Okay.

KO: I mean I, finding my birth family isn't really important to me.

OD: Right.

KO: It would've been important, like, when I was a teenager.

OD: Yeah.

KO: But at this point in my life, I mean I've lived my whole life, right, I've lived a whole life, so.

OD: No, I, no, I completely understand, and I think lots of people feel that way and that, you know, the priorities completely change.

KO: Yeah.

OD: So, what, what are your priorities now? Is it to, kind of, find out just what happened, or to expose something?

KO: Well, it's really... Sorry, go ahead.

OD: No that's, that's...

KO: It's really the exposure.

OD: Yeah okay.

KO: It's really, you know that, I think that if something was going on, then, people should know about it.

OD: Yeah.

KO: I think it's stopped by now, but still, you know, there is necessary accountability even if the place is closed. Even if it's not still happening.

OD: Mm-hmm, definitely. And so, you, you came back to *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*, well you came back to *location in Northern Ireland*, where your grandparents lived?

KO: No. I have never been back to Northern Ireland.

OD: Oh, okay.

KO: I have been to the Republic of Ireland which is where my mother – my adoptive mother – grew up.

OD: Got it.

KO: So, I have a lot of relatives there, but I've never been, I've never been to Northern Ireland.

OD: Okay. And what have you been shown from Good Shepherd and the people in *the mother and baby home*? Are the documents that you sent me all that you've been shown, or were they just the ones that...?

KO: That's all, that's all I have.

OD: Right so there was nothing, there was nothing that they showed you that you weren't able to keep or anything like that? That's the extent?

KO: No, I don't, you know I think I actually lost the letter that they sent me - when I first contacted them - saying that the documents ... that there were no documents, or there were no longer any documents, or that something had happened and they'd lost the documents, or, yeah ... That was a very brief letter.

OD: Okay.

KO: From, I think it was the convent, and that was, again, when I was sixteen.

OD: Yeah. Okay, so your story is really interesting, I'm just trying to piece together what you've said with these documents. The other thing I'm interested in is the, the consent form that your birth mother signed.

KO: Right.

OD: So, it seems interesting to me, because it was signed with the knowledge, it seems, that you were going to America.

KO: Mm-hmm.

OD: But that was signed, what, only sixteen days after your birth?

KO: That was signed sixteen days after my birth, and then I think a day after there was the Republic of Ireland birth certificate. I think it's dated later than one of the birth certificates.

OD: So, I'm just wondering, you know, were you signed over with the, kind of, idea that you might to go America, or were there specific people in mind for you at that point?

KO: Yeah, my parents already had a name for me. I mean, they seemed to have known, they seemed to have had a specific birth date in mind, and, you know, they have a lot of ... one ... I didn't send you a lot of the other things that I have, which are letters of references.

OD: Yeah.

KO: From, letters of reference from colleagues and friends, which I didn't think were pertinent. But this was going on for months before the actual adoption and it was sent to the orphanage, *name of baby home in Republic of Ireland*.

OD: Yeah. Yes, that's what I've got from you.

KO: Yeah.

OD: That's really interesting to me, because that suggests that there was, like you said, a sort of plan beforehand of...

KO: Mm-hmm.

OD: Of sending you to America. Did your birth, if you, if you'd rather not answer any of this it's fine, but I was wondering if your adopted parents, did they talk to you about your birth parents? Had they met them?

KO: No.

OD: Or at least your birth mother?

KO: They hadn't met them at all.

OD: Okay, interesting.

KO: They, they went to the orphanage.

OD: And picked you up from there?

KO: And that's where, yeah, that's where they arranged everything.

OD: Okay.

KO: So they didn't go to the *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*.

OD: ...Okay, interesting. And how, which ... have you been working with Family Care Society at all [to find records]?

KO: No.

OD: Okay, no problem. So, at the moment, is there anything that you're still trying to find out or anything that you're still working on. Have you written any more to any of these organisations?

KO: No, as I said, it's not really an important thing to me. It was just important to me that, you know, I had these documents that were, kind of, evidence.

OD: Yeah.

KO: And I did want to get them, you know, released to ... I didn't want to, anything to come back on my adopted parents.

[Section redacted that would identify KO]

OD: And I think a lot of people want the narrative to be, oh, she's searching, you know, for this etc. But actually, I think you're right, there's quite a lot about your story that just, you would quite like answers for, rather than necessarily finding people.

KO: Right.

OD: And actually, maybe just having some answers related to some of the documents that you have, because they are really interesting and, actually, they fill out a picture that is quite fascinating in terms of your movement as a baby.

KO: Mm-hmm.

OD: Were you given any help from the Good Shepherd Sisters, other than, kind of, what you've sent me. Was there any, did they meet with you, or...?

KO: I have had no contact with them at all.

OD: Okay right.

KO: Unless it was to them that I sent that original letter.

OD: Yeah, of course.

KO: I haven't had any, yeah.

OD: Okay.

KO: I haven't gotten in touch with them and they haven't gotten in touch with me.

OD: So, could I ask you just a little bit more, then, about that letter? One of the letters that you sent me was to do with them not being able to find records.

KO: Right.

OD: And I, I was just slightly unsure of, of what their claim was. So, I read the email through, and it seems that, I couldn't tell if they were claiming that the records had been destroyed, or if you needed to try looking somewhere else.

KO: I couldn't tell that either.

OD: Okay.

KO: But it seemed to me to imply that the records had been des-, destroyed.

OD: Yeah.

KO: Either by accident...

OD: Okay.

KO: ...or, yeah, in the process of moving or closing down the home, or whatever. But, yeah, it was just, like, those records no longer exist.

OD: Yeah definitely.

KO: Yeah.

OD: Okay, that's good, that's clarifying. Because I was unsure, and I wasn't sure if you had anymore clarity on that than I had.

KO: No, I don't.

OD: Your passport that you sent, as well. I'm just wondering, because this one says, obviously, that your pla-, that your place of birth is *location in Northern Ireland* and it gives the date.

KO: Yes.

OD: Do you still have this passport, or do you just have this copy of it?

KO: I do.

OD: You still have it? And so, I was wondering, was that something that was issued to you because they knew you were going to the United States?

KO: Well, I can tell you the story of when I was living with my aunt in *location in Republic of Ireland* Dublin, when I was, after I was brought down [there] by my aunt and uncle I lived with another aunt there because my grandmother didn't have any room.

OD: Yep.

KO: And my mother came over to visit frequently. This took a year and a half. I didn't come over to America until I was fourteen months old.

OD: Right.

KO: So, she came over several times, and they hadn't, if the orphanage had done this before, that is, get babies over to America, they hadn't set up any sort of process for her to do so easily.

OD: Right.

KO: So, she came over to visit me several times, and those times that she came to visit, she tried several means of getting me out of Dublin. So ... or out of, to America. You know, out of Ireland. She went to the American Embassy. She told them that she had been pregnant when she came over. They said they wanted to give her a medical exam to prove that, so she went away.

OD: Okay.

KO: Then she found a doctor who was willing to sign a document saying that she had given birth to me in Ireland.

OD: Right.

KO: And that's when they were able to issue me the passport. But she'd gone back to America by that time, so I don't know if one of my aunts actually was the one who did the paperwork for that.

OD: Wow.

KO: And she's very old, so when I try to question her [the aunt] she doesn't remember a lot.

OD: Yeah, that's understandable. I think...

KO: Yeah.

OD: ...lots of people are, kind of, running into those sorts of issues. And that's why lots of people are getting more frustrated about these kinds of answers. I think that's really interesting that, I didn't realise that you'd stayed for so long before you were able to get out, get back out.

KO: Yeah.

OD: But it's interesting that they moved you to *location in Republic of Ireland* so quickly.

KO: Yeah, they just, as far as the story goes, they just pretty much drove up there and picked me up and took me back.

OD: Yeah. And do you know, again, if you don't want to answer, that's fine, but do you know if you were, if your parents paid money for you?

KO: I'm pretty sure that they did. I mean, at least some sort of, you know, like, a donation to the orphanage perhaps.

OD: Mm-hmm.

KO: Or, yeah, a donation to the convent. But there is no sort of paperwork that has any sort of numbers on it.

OD: Yeah okay, right. So, then your timeline, then, as far as I can tell, is you're born in *location in Northern Ireland*, you're moved to *location in Republic of Ireland* very quickly, perhaps via somewhere else, perhaps not. We're not, I'm just trying to, sort of, piece that together. And then you are adopted fourteen months later from this children's home in *location in Republic of Ireland*.

KO: From my aunt's home in *location in Republic of Ireland*.

OD: From your aunt's home in *location in Republic of Ireland*, that was it, yeah.

KO: Yeah.

OD: So, you were adopted pretty quickly, and then your, but your mum struggles to get you out of the country.

KO: Right.

OD: Okay, interesting. So that explains, then, the consent, the consent form, and also, I was just slightly confused about the passport, I think, because I was wondering how, how you would've got something like that. So that's really helpful, thank you for explaining that. So, the only other, kind of, document that I was interested in – sorry, let me just find it – was the, yeah, the birth certificates. Were they kept together? I can't remember what you said.

KO: No.

OD: You had one of them...

KO: Oh ... so I had one that had just my birth mother's name on it with no father.

OD: Yep.

KO: Okay, so that's the one that I had since, for as long as I can remember.

OD: Yeah, okay.

KO: That was the one that my adopted mother kept in my baby book.

OD: Yes.

KO: And then I got all of the other documents seven years ago, about, you know, so, about seven years ago.

OD: That was it. Yes, sorry it's, sometimes it's tricky to just, I'm just trying to make sure that I'm perfectly clear about everything. So yeah, it says that you wrote to *name of private hospital redacted*.

KO: Right.

OD: So, what's quite interesting, I think, is that lots of babies from *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* are usually baptised in *name of NHS hospital redacted*.

KO: Mm-hmm.

OD: Sorry, are born in the hospital *name of NHS hospital redacted*, which is right down the road. But you seem to have gone to a different hospital, a private hospital.

KO: Mm-hmm.

OD: And I was wondering if that was, if that was something you knew anything about, why you would be, I mean, was it, maybe your, your adoptive parents had asked for that to be the case, or if it was just that you happened to be at that hospital. I don't know, I was wondering if you, if you knew anything about that.

KO: I don't know anything about it.

OD: Okay, no problem. Interesting. It might just, like I said it might just be, just an unusual birth, completely coincidental, but I was wondering if your parents had made any kind of request that you be born in a Catholic hospital or a private

hospital or anything like that. But that's fine. So, they, they are the ones who say that they are unable to help you with records.

KO: Okay.

OD: Yeah, okay, so that's interesting. Okay, so if I could then, I won't keep you much longer, because this has been really helpful, and I know you must have lots to do. I was just wondering if I could ask you two questions. The first one is, you've sort of answered it a little bit, but what was your, what was your main reason, I think, for, for kind of contacting people like Birth Mothers for Justice or equivalent? You sort of say that you, you wanted to, sort of, put these documents out there and make it aware that you, perhaps, had two birth certificates, or other potentially problematic things that had, that had come up. Was there anything you were hoping to come out of that?

KO: Well, there was actually my original, my original impetus was in reading the story about the, now I can't remember the name of the city and it was on the tip of my tongue, just a year ago, but the, the discovery all of all of the children's bodies.

OD: Oh, Tuam.

KO: This was in Ireland itself.

OD: Yeah, Tuam.

KO: Yeah, yeah, and I was just horrified by that. And I knew that I had been born at one of those, or that my birth mother had lived at one of those mother-baby homes.

OD: Yeah.

KO: And that's when I pulled out the documents. And I was like, you know, "if this is going on and if I can contribute to it..."

OD: Yeah.

KO: to this exposure of the things that were happening.

OD: Yeah.

KO: It's not, it's, you know, a document trail, so it's not something that might catch people's attention so readily, but if there is some sort of case...

OD: Yeah.

KO: ... being made, then I do have things that I can contribute, too, and contribute to that.

OD: Yeah, okay, that's really helpful. And the second thing was, you mentioned in your email, the email chain that you forwarded to me, that you were worried about, kind of, mistreatment, and I was ... I was wondering if that was still something that you were concerned about. Like, obviously...

KO: Oh, I would hate to, I would hate to think that my birth mother was mistreated. [redacted discussion of another person's birth mother] Yeah, so I mean ... although it's nothing that I could fix. I mean I would just, if something

did go on like that then it's another thing that I would want people to know about.

OD: Yeah, no, absolutely. And do you have any, kind of, was there anything that you were worried about that had come out of these documents that seemed to suggest that? Or was it simply that you had spoken to someone who'd had a similar experience?

KO: That I'd spoken to someone who had a similar experience ...

OD: Yeah.

KO: ... and that a lot of information seemed to be coming out about mother and baby homes around the time that I sent in those documents.

OD: Yeah, absolutely.

KO: Popular media and also, you know, some news reports, but it just seemed to be coming to a head.

OD: Absolutely. And I suppose it's always a concern isn't it? Because it's, it's something that's so, kind of, mysterious in lots of ways. And so if you meet someone whose mother was there the same time I can imagine it would trigger all kinds of questions.

KO: Yeah.

OD: Even if you're not necessarily looking for that person, I suppose those concerns are still very valid. And is there anything you would like to say for the

purposes of this, kind of, investigation? Is there anything that you want, kind of, recorded, or to go in with your, your interview?

KO: Oh I, I know that there are a lot of atrocities going on in the world today, but I do think that this merits some attention, and I don't think that it's getting the kind of attention that it deserves, and I hope that your report and your study, and similar studies, will give some, I don't know, allow this to progress in a way that will bring some attention to the mistreatment of women.

OD: Yeah.

KO: And the transportation, the human trafficking that's been going on, and that has been engaged in, apparently, by governments and by the Catholic Church.

OD: And is that a word that you would find applicable in your case?
Trafficking?

KO: I was, yeah, I was moved across, you know?

OD: Yeah, yeah.

KO: From Northern Ireland to Ireland and, yeah, and then to America, and I have three birth certificates. I mean, obviously something's going on, so.

OD: I think that's, that's really crystal clear, and I think that that, that was a really helpful, kind of, phrase to use that has come up a few times before, and I think does kind of refer to that movement. And thank you for that, kind of, final thought. This has been really helpful, thank you.

KO: Oh.

OD: If you, I'm kind of going to, if it's okay with you, share the documents with Sean.²

KO: Okay.

OD: So that he's able to, kind of, look through them too, and then we can, kind of, put them together with this interview and add it to our, our report that will hopefully come out by the summer.

KO: Oh fantastic.

OD: Yeah. We don't know, necessarily, what's going to be done with it, but it will be turned into, over to the Department of Health, by the summer. And hopefully, like you said, it will lead to some sort of, at least some answers or some discussion of these events in a more, kind of, public forum.

KO: Yeah.

OD: But I really thank you for your contribution.

KO: Oh, well thank you Livi.

OD: No, I really appreciate it. If you have any questions or anything, please let us know. And if you need to stay in contact to, kind of, check anything, please feel free.

² Sean O'Connell. The Principle Investigator on the oral history project.

KO: Okay.

OD: And we'll keep you in the loop with transcripts and etc. as soon as we know what's going on.

KO: Okay, and if you have any follow up questions then, you know, get in touch with me and we can arrange another time to talk.

OD: I would really appreciate that, yes.

KO: Yeah.

OD: Because I think, with these documents, I've sort of gone through them, but there may be more questions that come out of them.

KO: Right.

OD: So, if you, if that is possible that would be great. But we'll let you know if we, if we need that.

KO: Okay.

OD: Thank you so much, thank you. And have a lovely day.

KO: Alright, thank you, have a great weekend, have a great rest of the day.

OD: You to, thank you, bye.

KO: Thanks, bye.

[END OF INTERVIEW].